By the time Nehru died and Lal Bahadur Shastri became prime minister in 1964, decision making on foreign policy had become extremely personalized. The prime minister and his office were the key policymaking institution for foreign affairs. As a domestic politician with little interest in foreign affairs, Shastri gave more leeway to his external affairs minister Sardar Swaran Singh, who influenced foreign relations between 1964 and 1966.

Unlike Nehru, Shastri was not a prime minister willing to do everything himself. He needed someone he trusted to explain the content of voluminous diplomatic cables and administrative files. Thus, Lakshmi Kant Jha, a member of the Indian Civil Service from the British era, became secretary to the prime minister. Jha set up the prime minister's secretariat (PMS) that over time grew in power and size. During Shastri's time the permanent bureaucracy regained lost ground and, as Surjit Mansingh points out, Shastri made the prime minister's secretariat into 'a kind of super-ministry'. Diplomatic traffic was now routed through this secretariat and those serving in it had the prime minister's ear.

Indira Gandhi renamed the prime minister's secretariat as the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), which grew further not just in size but also in power and influence. The office now comprised officers, including those from the foreign service, who were deputed to the PMO to be the prime minister's eyes and ears. Missives and phone calls from the prime minister's office carried more weight than those from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). Indira Gandhi maintained control of foreign policy even as she appointed a succession of heavyweight Congress party leaders as her foreign ministers. These included Mahommedali Currim Chagla (1966–67), Dinesh Singh (1969–70), Sardar Swaran Singh (1970–74), Yashwant Rao Chavan (1974–77) and Pamulaparti Venkata Narasimha Rao (1980–84). The prime minister entrusted evaluations to a small group of advisers while Indira's foreign ministers simply implemented her decisions.